

Complex Prepositions

Quick Reference Guide

Complex prepositions are multi-word phrases that work like simple prepositions. They are more common in formal and professional English. This guide shows each complex preposition alongside its simpler everyday alternative.

Two-Word Prepositions

Complex Preposition	Formal Example	Simpler Alternative
According to	According to the report, sales increased by 10%.	The report says sales increased by 10%.
Due to	The match was cancelled due to heavy rain.	The match was cancelled because of heavy rain.
Apart from	Apart from the dessert, the meal was wonderful.	Except for the dessert, the meal was wonderful.
Ahead of	She arrived ahead of the deadline.	She arrived before the deadline.
Along with	He sent the files along with a short note.	He sent the files with a short note.

Three-Word Prepositions

Complex Preposition	Formal Example	Simpler Alternative
In spite of	In spite of the noise, she managed to sleep.	Despite the noise, she managed to sleep.
In addition to	In addition to English, he speaks two other languages.	As well as English, he speaks two other languages.
On behalf of	She accepted the award on behalf of her team.	She accepted the award for her team.

Complex Preposition	Formal Example	Simpler Alternative
In terms of	In terms of quality, this brand is the best.	For quality, this brand is the best.
In favour of	The committee voted in favour of the new policy.	The committee voted for the new policy.
By means of	They raised money by means of a charity event.	They raised money through a charity event.

Multi-Word Prepositions (4+ Words)

Complex Preposition	Formal Example	Simpler Alternative
As a result of	As a result of the storm, many roads were closed.	Because of the storm, many roads were closed.
With the exception of	With the exception of Jake, everyone passed the test.	Except for Jake, everyone passed the test.
In the event of	In the event of an emergency, call 999.	If there is an emergency, call 999.
With regard to	With regard to your question, I will reply by Friday.	About your question, I will reply by Friday.
For the sake of	She moved abroad for the sake of her career.	She moved abroad for her career.

*Remember: Complex prepositions are followed by a noun, a noun phrase, or a verb-ing form — never by a full clause with a subject and verb. If you need a full clause, use the conjunction equivalent instead (e.g. use **although** instead of **in spite of**).*